

ANI

LIGHTWEIGHTS Figurehead CMs like Bhajan Lal Sharma have cost the BJP dear

The BJP's impending headaches are the polls due in Maharashtra, Jharkhand and Haryana, where it dropped both seat and vote share

had added millions of votes to the BJP's kitty in recent elections, rallying behind PM Modi over a decade, buying into his twin planks of nationalism and development. The disruption of the feedback loop played out here too. The common threads sewing up these latitudes of anger? An unrequited quest for government jobs, the related apprehensions over the reservation policy, the increasing immiseration of the farm economy.

In the last week of February, UP saw a cancellation of exams to recruit/promote constables after allegations of another paper leak: 4.82 million aspirants had appeared for 60,244 posts just the previous week. Youth anger blurred into caste anxieties: non-Jatav Dalits, a segment the BJP had assiduously wooed, sprang to the INDIA camp; even Jatavs shifted their loyalties from the BSP. Dalits, as a whole, reacted to the narrative about the threat to the Constitution, emanating originally from overconfident BJP candidates and subsequently fanned by the Opposition. Non-Yadav OBCs, too, opted to vote on the basis of socioeconomic distress rather than caste affiliations. Alongside, with the Thakurs angry and Brahmins ambivalent in Yogi raj, a core vote subsidence saw the BJP's vote share drop 8.6 percentage points. Net loss: 29 seats. Even Ayodhya.

At the same time, Punjab's farm unions began another march on Delhi, demanding the fulfillment of promises made at the end of the 13-month siege the national capital had witnessed in 2020-21. Another theatre of dissent and repression was staged at the Shambhu and Khanauri borders between Punjab and Haryana—with teargas fogs and nailed highways creating their own visual narrative. Protesting unions continued to stalk BJP candidates in western UP, Haryana, Punjab and Rajasthan, turning Jats into an archipelago of anger. In Maharashtra, a new reservation law passed in early March to placate agitating Marathas ended up angering other OBC groups, particularly the related Kunbi community who feared an ingress into their quotas. Result: NDA faced a rout in Vidarbha, the cotton belt it had dominated in 2014-2019, as angry Kunbis swelled the ranks of the rival Maha Vikas Aghadi, which was already bolstered by Dalit-Muslim refugees. Only Nitin Gadkari and two others escaped the wrath. Nor, in the event, did the quota lollipop soothe the Marathas, with their pride hurt by the two big regional party splits wrought by a 'Gujarati-dominated' BJP. A lone alliance win framed the washout in Marathwada, and Mumbai saw the unlikely 'Ma-Mu' phenomenon, as Marathas and Muslims converged against the BJP.

RAYS OF SUNSHINE

The biggest good news story came from Odisha, where decade-long efforts have borne fruit—in the shape of 78 assembly seats. For the first time, the party will have its own chief minister in an east coast state. With its allies, the TDP and Pawan Kalyan's Janasena Party, it will also enter the new Andhra Pradesh government. It also breached the Left-Congress fortress in Kerala for the first time, getting an MP there.In Telangana, its eight seats have come with a vote share boost of 15.4 per cent. In both Punjab and Tamil Nadu—traditionally non-receptive to Hindutva narratives—the BJP contested without its traditional allies and scored more votes than them. In Punjab, it got a lead in 24 assembly segments and netted 18.5 per cent votes; the vote share increased by 7.6 percentage points in Tamil Nadu. The immediate headaches are the impending assembly polls in Haryana, Jharkhand and Maharashtra later this year—all states where the BJP dropped seat and vote shares. There is plenty to think about, but little time left for urgent recuperative action. ■